

Don't Just Work Hard, Work Smart: Pat in Her Own Words

Coach Pat Summitt

I congratulated and said, "Good job. But let me tell you one thing, Pat Hatmaker." I said, "I cannot believe you didn't want the ball. We practice that every day." And I said, "We're getting ready to play for a championship. You know, folks?" And I'm just reaming her out. And then the crafty little sucker – we've all got one – the crafty little sucker said, "Hang on, Coach. Hang on, Coach. You play for a title tomorrow. You've never won one."

Ah! Immediately, I flipped the switch. You have to do that sometimes, don't you? When things aren't going the way they need to be going, you better flip the switch. I flipped that switch and I said, "You know what, Pat? I bet you learned today and you're going to be even better tomorrow." And I just started building her up because the crafty little sucker scared me. Scared me! I thought, "We'll get blown out if she doesn't play." So, the only point guard you've got -- how smart are you? So, I tried to build her up.

We went out the next day and she played a pretty good game, but we didn't win a championship. We were in seven title games before we ever won one. Seven times we went to the big dance and played for the title before we won one.

So, you've got to be persistent, don't you? You've got to keep building people up. And that's what I did that day. And while it didn't work, it made a difference, thanks to the crafty little sucker.

But what I went back, and I realized I did not know my personnel. You better know them. You better know your personnel. I didn't know she didn't want the ball.

Every year we do what we call Predictive Index. It's a personality profile. And I know who wants the ball. I know who likes pressure and who doesn't. I know who pays attention to detail. I know who can be really persistent; and the players that are very, very short-fused and short-minded. I use that as a tool to help me when I get in that situation. It has been a powerful tool. I know who the most competitive people are on the team. I know who really doesn't care if we keep score, and that's not good in my business. But there's a way you can dial those people up, too.

So, I took that situation and tried to make something really good out of it. And as a result, I continue to learn and grow. I bet you do too, don't you? Don't ever believe that you've "arrived." You never, ever "arrive."

If you get to the top, it can be very temporary if you think you just belong there. You've got to remember how you got there. Don't ever forget how you got there. And that's what can inspire you to strive to be on top all the time.

